



Installing Linux on a Mac

The Penguin in the Apple camp? As incredible as that sounds, there are many reasons to install Linux on the Apple Macintosh—an urge to take ol’ Tux for a spin, or maybe migrate to freedom-land to avoid the increasing malware. Whatever the reasons, few geeks can pass up a chance to, as Mark Twain said, “Do the right thing; it will gratify some people and astonish the rest.” This article takes readers through the installation process.

There are a couple of ways to actually install a Linux distribution on a Mac. One way is to set up a virtual machine (VM) and install Linux into that. Another is to install natively (on the ‘bare metal’). We will be doing both here.

The Mac I used to write this article is an iMac 27 with a quad-core Intel Core i7, 8 GB of RAM, and 1 TB of hard drive space. A Mac with a more modest configuration will also fly with Linux. Loads of RAM and HDD space help the VM approach—after all, it would be cool to run both OSs simultaneously and at decent speeds, right?

Installing Linux in a VM

I chose to use the Ubuntu distro, and the virtualisation software is Oracle VirtualBox. The links are at the end of the article so visit the site and download a copy of VirtualBox. This would be a DMG file, which you need to mount, and run the MPKG file within it. Simple, right? Fire up VirtualBox

after it’s installed, and follow the steps below.

Click the **New** button in the main toolbar to bring up the *Create a New Virtual Machine* wizard. Press *Continue* to proceed from the introduction page. The *VM Name* and *OS Type* page tries guessing the guest OS from the name (clever, isn’t it?). If you were to name it something unique, select the *Operating System* as *Linux* and *Version* as *Ubuntu*. Click *Continue* to proceed. On the *Memory* page, leave the default of 512. Hit *Continue*. Again, leave the *Virtual Hard Disk* page as-is. The default 8 GB is more than sufficient, just as the dialogue box says.

The next page asks about the virtual hard disk file format you want. Stick to the suggested *VDI (VirtualBox Disk Image)*. Click *Continue*, and select *Dynamically allocated* in the details page. This way, it won’t chomp up 8 GB in one go. Next, enter a filename for the virtual disk; you can move the slider or enter a new value if you wish to modify the size. Hit *Create* on the summary screen; this completes